missiles from Cuba on any basis other than the removal of American missiles from Turkey. That and only that, in Kennedy's mind, would give diplomacy a chance. Thus he hoped that the initial wire reports were correct, and that Khrushchev had indeed offered a swap. "Let's wait and let's assume that this is an accurate report of what he is now proposing this morning," he told his aides.[3]

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JOHN KENNEDY AND HIS ADVISERS FIRST BROACHED THE question of the American missiles in Turkey at the very first session of his Cuban crisis group. On October 16, the first day of the crisis, Dean Rusk mentioned Turkey as he recounted for Kennedy John McCone's hypothesis explaining why Khrushchev might have decided to put his missiles in Cuba. Khrushchev, argued Rusk, knew that the United States had nuclear superiority over the USSR. "Also, we have nuclear weapons nearby, in Turkey and places like that," added Rusk.[4]

The Jupiters—the first nuclear-tipped medium-range ballistic missiles (MRBMs), designed by Hitler's main rocket man and one of the founders of the American missile program, Wernher von Braun—were capable of delivering a 2,000-pound nuclear bomb at a distance of up to 1,700 miles. They were built first and foremost for Europe, but the French refused to take them—President Charles de Gaulle was developing his own nuclear and missile programs. But the Italians and the Turks, who had no plans to go nuclear themselves, accepted the Jupiters in deals signed in 1959. The decisions were made by Eisenhower, but deployment of the missiles in both Italy and Turkey began under the Kennedy administration, in the summer of 1961.

There were political concerns about the deployment. Some Democratic senators, such as Albert Gore Sr., the father of future vice president Al Gore, questioned the wisdom of the move, considering the missiles nothing short of a provocation. He asked Dean Rusk what the American attitude would be if Khrushchev put missiles in Cuba. Gore's comments, made at a closed session of the Senate in February 1961, were generally ignored at the